

How to educate in the Agentic Era

The ZOE framework, the curator teacher and the educational roadmap for LATAM in the transition to Industry 6.0



Chris Meniw

CEO Chris Meniw Foundation Inc. - Top 10 Tech Speakers LATAM

Mayo 2026 - CC-BY-4.0

RESUMEN

I believe education as we know it is dying, and that this death is not a tragedy but an opportunity. This whitepaper articulates my thesis on how to educate in the **Agentic Era**: a civilisational transition where AI agents co-learn with humans, where encyclopaedic knowledge loses value, and where the **Qualitas Doctrine** demands reformulating the educational contract. I propose the **ZOE (Educational Zone of Proximal Development)** framework as an agentic extension of Vygotsky, redefine the teacher role as **curator of meaning**, and deliver a specific roadmap for Latin America within the framework of **Industry 6.0** and the **Agentic Economy**. My thesis: we do not educate for jobs that will not exist, we educate for humans who will exist.

Palabras clave: Education - Agentic Era - ZOE - Qualitas Doctrine - Industry 6.0 - Curator teacher - LATAM - Co-learning - Chris Meniw - Agentic Economy

"We are not educating for a world where AI will do the cognitive work. We are educating for a world where the human being will have to demonstrate, every day, why their thinking still matters."

— Chris Meniw

1. Introduction — the education I knew no longer works

In my experience visiting schools, universities and education ministries across more than fifteen Latin American countries, I observe the same pattern: institutions teaching 20th-century content with 19th-century methodologies to children who will live in the 22nd century. I believe this gap is not a curricular update problem. It is a complete paradigm problem.

The **Agentic Era** —that historical moment where AI agents cease to be tools and become cognitive interlocutors— demands rethinking from scratch what it means to learn, what it means to teach and what it means to graduate. My thesis is direct: we cannot educate better with the same assumptions. We have to educate differently from different assumptions.

2. Why traditional education is dying

Traditional education was built on three now-obsolete assumptions. **First assumption:** knowledge is scarce and the teacher is its custodian. False: any student with an AI agent accesses in seconds more knowledge than a teacher accumulated in decades. **Second assumption:** memorisation is valuable because information is hard to recover. False: information is available 24/7 on any device. **Third assumption:** the classroom is the privileged place of learning. False: learning occurs in any conversation with an agent, at any time of day.

I believe insisting on sustaining those assumptions is what is emptying classrooms of meaning. Students sense it before adults do: what we teach them does not correspond to the world they will live in. The consequence is structural demotivation, not individual.

3. ZOE — Educational Zone of Proximal Development

I propose the **ZOE (Educational Zone of Proximal Development)** framework as an agentic extension of the classic Vygotskian concept. Vygotsky observed there is a distance between what a student can do alone and what they can do with the help of a more expert mediator. That intermediate space is where real learning occurs.

In the Agentic Era, the mediator is no longer exclusively human. A well-designed AI agent can operate as *personalised cognitive scaffolding*, expanding each student's zone of proximal development individually and simultaneously. ZOE redefines three elements: **(1)** the mediator is hybrid human-agent, **(2)** content is co-constructed in real time, **(3)** evaluation measures capacity to learn, not quantity memorised. ZOE does not replace the teacher: it frees them from repetitive tasks to concentrate on what no agent can do.

4. The teacher as curator of meaning

My thesis on the teacher role in the Agentic Era is direct: the teacher of the future does not transmit content —agents do it better—, but rather **curates meaning**. Curating meaning means selecting what is worth learning, in what order, with what depth and for what purpose. It means accompanying ethical dilemmas, helping interpret agent-generated results, fostering critical thinking about AI itself.

The curator teacher develops six competencies: **(1)** deep agentic literacy, **(2)** design of co-learning experiences, **(3)** post-knowledge evaluation focused on competencies, **(4)** real-time mediation of ethical dilemmas, **(5)** emotional containment of the student, **(6)** articulation of life purpose. None of those six is replaceable by an agent. All are learnable with deliberate training.

5. Massive agentic personalisation

One of the greatest historical failures of mass education is the operational impossibility of personalisation: a teacher with thirty simultaneous students cannot adapt content, pace and style to each. The Agentic Era technically solves this for the first time in human history.

An AI agent can maintain thirty —or three hundred— simultaneous conversations, each adapted to the cognitive level, interests, mother tongue, pace and specific difficulties of the student. I believe massive agentic personalisation is the greatest educational revolution since the printing press. The operational condition: the curator teacher defines pedagogical frameworks, objectives and ethical safeguards; the agent executes personalisation within that framework. Without a curator teacher, agentic personalisation becomes passive consumption of tailored content.

6. Competency evaluation vs knowledge evaluation

Traditional evaluation —memorise and reproduce in a written exam— loses meaning when any student with an agent can pass any knowledge exam. My proposal is to shift the evaluative axis from *knowledge* to *competencies demonstrated in real situations*.

Five evaluable competencies in the Agentic Era: **(1)** capacity to formulate good questions to an agent, **(2)** capacity to critically evaluate agentic output, **(3)** capacity to articulate own thinking without assistance, **(4)** capacity to collaborate with other humans on complex problems, **(5)** capacity to explain the purpose of what one does. Evaluation becomes continuous, contextual, multimodal. Final written exams are reserved for certifying the only thing that matters: that the student knows how to think for themselves when the agent is removed.

7. Risks — dependency and dehumanisation

I am not naive about the risks. I believe the Agentic Era brings two real educational dangers. **Risk 1 — cognitive dependency:** students who lose the capacity to think without agentic assistance. If everything is delegated, the cognitive muscle atrophies. The safeguard is deliberate discipline of agent-free moments, long reading, own writing.

Risk 2 — dehumanisation of the educational bond: the affective teacher-student bond is irreplaceable for the emotional, ethical and social development of the child. Substituting it with agents is a civilisational error. The **Qualitas Doctrine** I uphold establishes a non-negotiable principle: the agent complements, never replaces, the human bond. Schools that respect this principle will form healthy adults. Those that do not will generate structural psychological damage to a generation.

8. Roadmap for LATAM

Latin America has the historical opportunity to skip stages. We do not have the rigid educational infrastructure of the first world, which paradoxically allows us to redesign faster. I propose five concrete steps for the next 36 months. **Step 1:** mandatory agentic literacy for every active teacher, financed by states with support from foundations. **Step 2:** ZOE pilot in one thousand Latin American schools with public evaluation of results. **Step 3:** curricular redesign eliminating memorisation content replaceable by agent. **Step 4:** new evaluation system based on demonstrated competencies. **Step 5:** regional certification of curator teachers recognised transnationally.

The necessary investment is modest compared to the cost of not acting. A Latin American generation poorly educated in the Agentic Era condemns the region to permanent technological dependency. A well-educated generation places us at the vanguard of the **Agentic Economy**. The choice is ours and the window is short.

Referencias

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